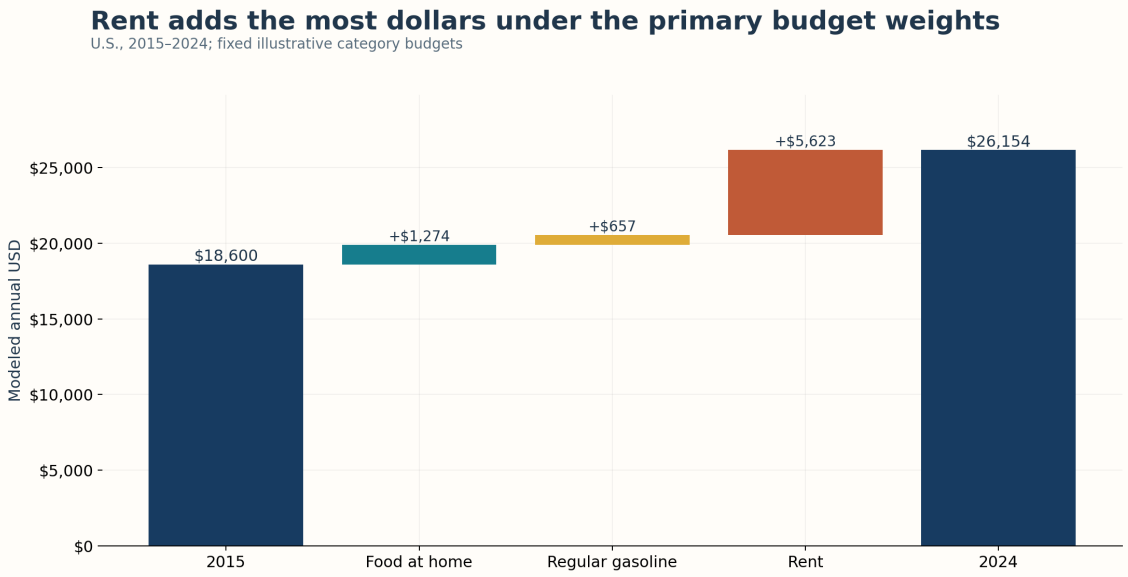
Income outpaced this selected-essential budget

Renter median income grew **51.8%**. The primary illustrative budget grew **40.6%**.

The resulting affordability index is **108.0** (2015=100), or 8.0% above baseline. This aggregate model does not establish that every renter became financially better off.



Source: BLS CPI / EIA. Contributions depend on baseline weights; they do not describe observed household spending.

Rent drives the modeled dollar increase

Rent adds $5,623, or 74.4%, of the $7,554 modeled annual increase. The result depends on the fixed budget weights.

2015 annual assumptions: rent $12,000, groceries $4,800, gasoline $1,800. Official price relatives hold this structure fixed. Utilities, taxes, healthcare and other costs are omitted.

Use the model to test assumptions

Budget monitoring

Replace the illustrative weights with household-specific inputs. Rent drives 74.4% of this model's increase, but household circumstances can differ.

State housing screening

Keep rent/income proxies separate from actual rent-burden prevalence. Retain published margins of error and avoid treating close state ranks as precise.

Fuel and grocery planning

Monthly change Pearson correlation is -0.073, versus 0.751 for levels. Descriptive lag tests do not demonstrate causation or forecasting value.

Twelve-month stress tests

Historical-quantile paths from September 2026 price levels yield terminal modeled monthly costs of $2,405, $2,429 and $2,509. These are assumptions, not forecast intervals.

Coverage boundaries

Annual affordability stops in 2024. Standard ACS 2020 is missing. National prices are not state prices. ACS households and the illustrative budget represent different statistical objects. Income includes more than wages and is before tax.

Sources and reproducible methods: github.com/amanubhi/american-affordability-index
Census ACS 1-year Summary Files, BLS CPI-U, EIA regular gasoline. Separate item drilldown: Kaggle/BLS AP.